



Hour

Love's time's beggar, but even a single hour,

bright as a dropped coin, makes love rich.

We find an hour together, spend it not on flowers

or wine, but the whole of the summer sky and a grass ditch.

For thousands of seconds we kiss; your hair

like treasure on the ground; the Midas light

turning your limbs to gold. Time slows, for here

we are millionaires, backhanding the night

so nothing dark will end our shining hour,

no jewel hold a candle to the cuckoo spit

hung from the blade of grass at your ear,

no chandelier or spotlight see you better lit

than here. Now. Time hates love, wants love poor,

but love spins gold, gold, gold from straw.



'Love's time's beggar'

OPENING METHOD

The Metaphor

Love is compared to a beggar — impoverished, never possessing enough time. The image opens the poem with a sense of lack and longing.

The repeated possessive sound in '**Love's time's**' feels tight and pressured, as though time is being squeezed out of love's grasp.

Why open with poverty?

Duffy immediately establishes the central tension of the poem: love is rich in feeling but poor in time. By beginning with this image of begging, she sets up everything that follows as a kind of defiance — love will find a way to be wealthy despite what time denies it.

❓ Why might Duffy open with an image of poverty?

'Bright as a dropped coin'

THE HOUR AS WEALTH

The Simile

The hour is compared to a **dropped coin** — small, accidental, easily overlooked. A dropped coin is not a gift; it is found by chance.

Catching the Light

Yet a dropped coin **catches the light**. It glints. Duffy suggests that even a brief, ordinary moment can become precious when love illuminates it.

Transformation

The simile introduces the poem's central idea: love does not need grand gestures. It transforms the **small and ordinary** into something that shines.

❓ What does this image suggest about how love changes ordinary things?

'Not on flowers or wine'

REJECTING CONVENTIONAL ROMANCE

Expected vs. Chosen

Flowers and wine are the **expected tokens of romance** — conventional, purchased, performative. Duffy's lovers reject them entirely.

Instead, they spend their hour on **'the whole of the summer sky and a grass**

'The Midas light / turning your limbs to gold'

GOLD AND TRANSFORMATION

The Allusion

King Midas turned everything he touched to gold. Here, it is **light itself** — the light of the hour — that performs the transformation. The beloved's body becomes golden, precious, mythic.

Love Changes Perception

The image does not suggest the beloved is literally golden. Rather, it suggests that **love alters how the speaker sees**. The moment they share makes the beloved appear more valuable than anything money could buy.

There is also a subtle warning in the Midas myth — his touch was a curse. Duffy may hint that love's intensity carries its own danger.

Effect of the Reference

- Elevates the beloved to mythological status
- Links love to transformation and wonder
- Connects to the poem's wider gold/wealth imagery
- Introduces a note of fragility beneath the beauty

❓ What is the effect of the Midas reference?

'Backhanding the night'

FIGHTING THE NIGHT

Personification

Night becomes a **physical presence** that can be struck. It is no longer an abstract concept but an opponent – something the lovers can actively resist.

What Night Represents

Night suggests **ending, darkness, and separation**. It is the moment the hour runs out. The lovers are fighting against time itself.

The Verb 'Backhanding'

The verb is **forceful and dismissive** – a backhand is contemptuous, not a careful blow. The lovers do not fear the night; they swat it away.

❓ What does this violent verb suggest about the lovers' attitude to time?

'No jewel hold a candle to the cuckoo spit'

NATURE OVER LUXURY

The Surprising Comparison

Cuckoo spit is the frothy secretion left by insects on grass stems — **not conventionally beautiful**. Yet Duffy places it above a jewel.

The comparison is deliberately shocking. It forces the reader to reconsider what beauty means when love is present.

A Natural Earring

The phrase '**at your ear**' positions the cuckoo spit like a piece of jewellery — a natural earring that no chandelier could outshine. Love reframes the world entirely.

The Wider Point

Duffy argues that **love makes the tiny natural detail more precious than luxury**. Wealth is not found in jewels but in the ability to see beauty in what others overlook.



How does Duffy make something unattractive seem beautiful?

'No chandelier or spotlight see you better lit / than here. Now.'

ARTIFICIAL LIGHT CANNOT COMPETE



Chandeliers

Chandeliers suggest **wealth and grandeur** — the light of ballrooms and palaces. Duffy rejects them. No artificial opulence can match the light of this moment.



Spotlights

Spotlights suggest **performance and display** — being watched, being staged. Love is not a performance. It does not need an audience.



'Here. Now.'

The **sentence fragments** are striking. Isolated by full stops, they fix attention entirely on the present. The poem refuses to look forward or back — only this moment matters.

❓ Why does Duffy isolate the words 'here' and 'now'?

The Ending

TIME, LOVE, AND GOLD

'Time hates love, wants love poor'

Time is **personified as hostile** — it does not merely pass, it actively hates. It wants love to be impoverished, to have nothing.

The poem returns to the opening image of poverty, completing a circular structure. Time has been the enemy throughout, and here it is named directly.

'Love spins gold, gold, gold from straw'

The allusion to **Rumpelstiltskin** is triumphant. In the fairy tale, straw is spun into gold by magic. Here, love performs the same miracle — transforming the plain and ordinary into something of immense value.

The **repetition of 'gold'** is emphatic and joyful. After the threat of time, the ending feels abundant, overflowing. Love wins. The poem ends not in loss but in richness.

3×

'Gold' repeated

The triple repetition creates a sense of abundance and triumph at the poem's close.

14

Lines in the sonnet

Duffy uses the traditional sonnet form — associated with love poetry — but subverts its conventions throughout.

2

Fairy tale allusions

Midas and Rumpelstiltskin both frame love as a magical, transformative force.

Final Writing Question

ESSAY PRACTICE

How does Duffy present love as powerful in 'Hour'?

Use the four bullet points below to structure your response. Each one points to a different layer of the poem's argument.

1

Love vs. Time

Explore the conflict between love and time – how time is personified as hostile, and how love resists and defies it through language, imagery, and structure.

2

Wealth and Gold

Analyse the imagery of wealth, coins, gold, and poverty. How does Duffy use the extended metaphor of richness to argue that love creates its own value?

3

Ordinary into Valuable

Consider how ordinary natural details – a grass ditch, cuckoo spit, summer light – are transformed by love. What does this suggest about love's power to change perception?

4

The Effect of the Ending

Evaluate the impact of the final line. How does the repetition of 'gold, gold, gold' and the Rumpelstiltskin allusion create a sense of triumph over time?